

# 7 key facts about male teachers

Oct 31, 2024 | by Ben Smith, Richard V. Reeves

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## Summary

The share of male teachers in public K-12 education is shrinking, as shown in our [previous brief on “Missing Mistery”](#). Here we dive deeper using survey data from the National Center for Education Statistics to examine changes in the share of male teachers by school level, finding the most dramatic declines at the secondary level. We also describe gender differences in subject teaching areas (men now comprise a minority of CTE teachers) and the routes men and women take into and out of the teaching profession (men are more likely to choose teaching as a second career).

## Key takeaways

The share of male teachers in secondary schools has dropped from 48% to 36% since 1987.

In 1987 men accounted for 75% of career and technical education teachers: by 2020 this share had dropped to just 45%.

Just one in four undergraduate education degrees are awarded to men.

Men are 11 percentage points more likely than women to be ‘career switchers’ into teaching (25% v. 14%).

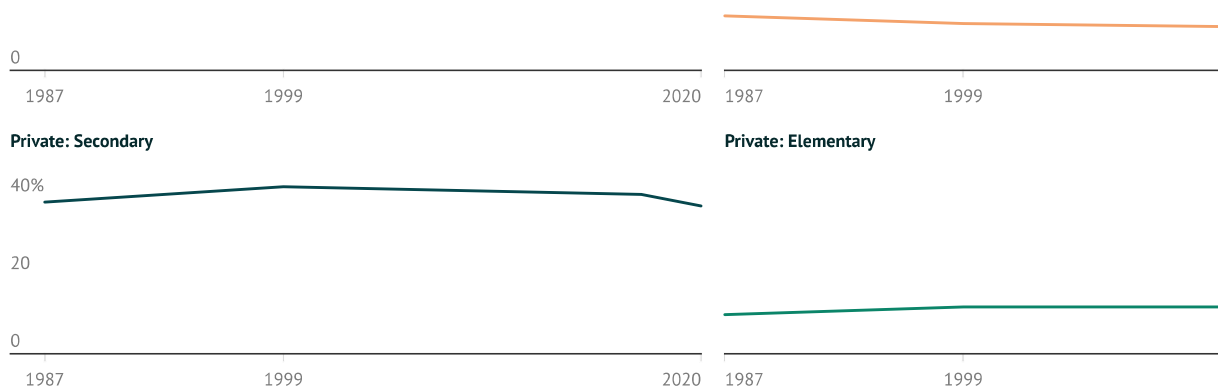
Nine out of 10 male teachers are satisfied with their job, as are female teachers.

Men leaving teaching are most likely headed for another career, while women leave for personal reasons, including care responsibilities.

Male teachers are three times more likely than their female peers to switch into a leadership role (60% v. 19%).

## There's Been A Sharp Drop In The Share Of Male High School And Middle School Teachers

Share of male teachers in elementary (pre-K-6th) and secondary (7th-12th) schools from 1987-2020



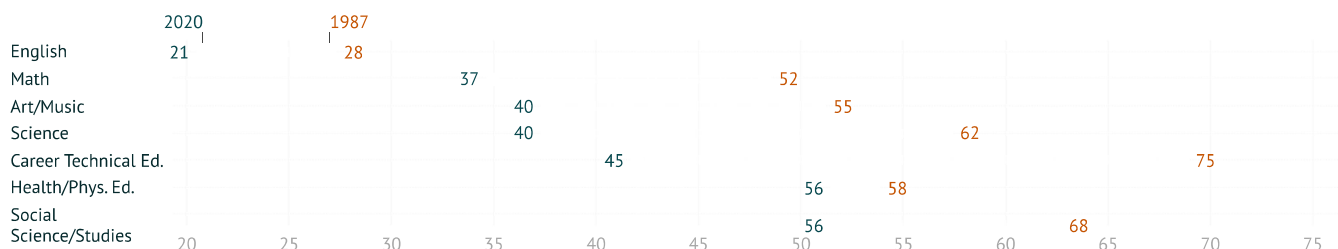
Source: AIBM analysis of Schools and Staffing Survey (Teachers) and National Teacher and Principal Survey (Teachers)

Overall, the share of male teachers in public schools (both elementary and secondary) has declined from 30% in 1987 to 23% in 2022. In elementary schools (pre-kindergarten to 6th grade) the male share has always been low, and has dropped further, from 14% to 11%. In secondary schools (7th to 12th grade) the share is higher but has fallen more significantly, from 48% to 36%.

## DATA NOTE

## Male teacher share declined across subjects, especially CTE

Male teacher share at the secondary (7th-12th) level as % of total by subject (1987-2020)



Source: AIBM analysis of Schools and Staffing Survey (Teachers, 1987-88) and National Teacher and Principal Survey (Teachers, 2020-21)

The share of male teachers has declined across all of the seven main subject areas at the secondary level. The biggest drop has been in career technical education (CTE), from 75% in 1987 to 45% in 2020.<sup>1</sup> Men now make up the majority of secondary teachers in just two subjects: Health/Physical Education and Social Studies.



|                                                                       |     |     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|-----|
| 2004)                                                                 |     |     |
| 2. Get an education degree in 2008<br>(among those who obtained a BA) | 3%  | 9%  |
| 3. Teaching in 2009<br>(among 2008 Ed. Degree grads)                  | 47% | 54% |
| 4. Still teaching in 2018<br>(among those teaching 2009)              | 60% | 54% |



Source: NCES Digest of Education Statistics and Baccalaureate and Beyond (2008/18)

The traditional path into teaching typically involves earning an undergraduate education degree, followed by licensure and a teaching job. Men are less likely than women to take each of these steps towards a career in the classroom.

We examine gender gaps at four key points in the teacher pipeline, using longitudinal data from the Baccalaureate and Beyond 2008/18 study<sup>2</sup>:

**Going to college:** Almost all teaching positions require a 4-year degree. In 2004, only 40% of men enrolled in a four-year college immediately after high school, compared to 49% of women. (This gap has widened over time—by 2022 only 38% of men enrolled in a 4-year college compared to 51% of women). Completion rates for men also lag, with only 33% of men and 42% of women in the 2004 cohort completing their degrees within four years.

**Getting an education degree:** Among college graduates, three times as many women as men earned an education degree. This gap should be seen in light of a general decline in the attainment of undergraduate education degrees. In 2008-09, 21,000 (21%) of 102,000 education degrees were awarded to men. By 2023, the overall number dropped to 89,000, with just 15,000 (17%) going to men.

**Entering Teaching:** Overall, only 47% of men who graduated with an education bachelor’s in 2008 were working as a regular teacher in 2009, compared to 54% of their female peers. By 2012, the gender gap had closed, with 63% of both men and women with education degrees having entered the profession. The reason for this difference in timing is unclear but may involve a combination of personal preferences—men in particular may be more sensitive to pay and opportunity costs—and differences in demand by teaching subject.<sup>3</sup>

**Staying in teaching:** Once in the profession, male teachers are at least as likely to remain as female teachers. Sixty percent of men who went straight into teaching from college are still in the profession ten years later, compared to 54% of women.

## More Men Switch Into Teaching Later

Proportion of men and women who responded that this was their main activity before teaching.





Other

7%  
7%

Source: National Teacher and Principal Survey (Public Teachers, 2020-21)

Male teachers are more likely than female teachers to take a non-traditional pathway into the classroom. One in four male teachers (25%) say they enter teaching from another occupation outside of the education field, compared to 14% of female teachers. Consequently, 26% of men have alternative teaching certifications, versus 18% of women.<sup>4</sup> These can include programs like Teach For America, teacher residencies, online programs, or certain types of grow-your-own (GYO) programs run by local school districts or universities—which aim to “expedite the transition of nonteachers to a teaching career.”

## Male Teachers Like Their Jobs

Share of male and female teachers agreeing with the following statements

|       | Satisfied being a teacher here | Teaching is worth it | Satisfied with pay |
|-------|--------------------------------|----------------------|--------------------|
| Men   | 89%                            | 76%                  | 54%                |
| Women | 90%                            | 75%                  | 48%                |



Source: National Teacher and Principal Survey (Public Teachers, 2020-21)

The good news is that both men and women in the teaching profession report high levels of job satisfaction (note that the data is from 2020-21). Nine out of ten teachers are satisfied with their positions, and three in four say that “teaching is worth it.” Satisfaction with pay is lower, but perhaps surprisingly is slightly higher among male teachers (54%) than female teachers (48%).

### DATA NOTE

## If Men Leave Teaching, It's For Another Career

|                                                      | Men | Women |
|------------------------------------------------------|-----|-------|
| Left to pursue another career or to enroll in school | 35% | 13%   |
| Left classroom teaching but remained in education    | 24% | 22%   |
| Another reason not listed                            | 17% | 15%   |
| Dissatisfied with teaching                           | 12% | 11%   |
| Personal reasons**                                   | 9%  | 34%   |
| Laid off or involuntarily transferred*               | 2%  | 1%    |



Over a third (35%) of the men who leave teaching do so either for another career or to get more education, compared to 13% of female leavers. Women leaving teaching are much more likely than men to say this is for personal reasons, almost certainly including caring responsibilities (34% v. 9%).

Most Men Changing Jobs Within Education Take Leadership Roles

|                             | Male | Female |
|-----------------------------|------|--------|
| School leader               | 60%  | 19%    |
| Other position*             | 28%  | 34%    |
| Other school specialist**   | 11%  | 10%    |
| Academic school specialist* | 1%   | 33%    |
| District leader**           |      | 4%     |

\* Male estimate has standard errors >30%  
\*\* Male and female estimates have standard errors >30% or are unavailable.  
Source: Baccalaureate and Beyond (2008/18)



Male teachers who leave their current position are three times more likely to do so for a leadership role than female teachers who are changing roles (60% v. 19%). A third of female teachers switching roles (33%) are opting to become academic specialists within the school: almost no men take this route.

DATA NOTE

Conclusion

Men are increasingly underrepresented in teaching, as our previous work shows. This analysis of the male teacher pipeline is necessarily broad and low-resolution, and corroboration with other data sources would be valuable. Still, it suggests that the most promising opportunities may lie earlier in the process. With fewer men following traditional pathways and more entering as career switchers, addressing barriers and promoting alternative routes into teaching could help attract more men to the profession.

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